

“There’s a misconception that MSP is needed everywhere”

Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare; and Rural Development, talks about agriculture, farmers’ incomes, and more

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When Shivraj Singh Chouhan was the Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh, the state had an agricultural growth rate of 6.5% per annum, while the national rate of growth was just 3.7%. The agricultural revolution in Madhya Pradesh caught everyone’s attention. The biggest question now is whether 65-year-old Chouhan, as the Union Minister of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare, can implement it across India. Chouhan, who also holds the portfolio of Rural Development, discusses his vision and the challenges in an interaction with *Rahul Kanwal*, News Director of India Today and Aaj Tak and Executive Director of *Business Today*, and BTTV Managing Editor *Siddharth Zarabi*, at the BT India@100 summit. Edited excerpts:

RK: One of the biggest promises made by the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government in 2016 was to double farmers’ incomes by 2022. That promise is lagging. Do you think farmers’ incomes can be doubled, and how?

A: I disagree that incomes haven’t increased. Under the leadership of PM Modi, several revolutionary changes have taken place in agriculture over the past 10 years. Our strategy aims to increase farmers’ incomes and ensure the country’s food security. Our population is 1.4 billion today and will grow to 1.6 billion by 2047. As purchasing power increases, so will the consumption of food items. From that perspective, we need to meet India’s needs.

Efforts to increase farmers’ incomes will continue. We will also meet the country’s needs. Now, the PM’s resolve and my dream is for India to become the world’s food basket. We will not just meet our own needs; we can also meet the world’s food needs. We are moving in that direction. I am happy to say that this year alone, we exported 4 million tonnes of rice. Madhya Pradesh’s Sharbati wheat is known worldwide. **Our strategy includes increasing production; reducing production costs; ensuring fair and remunerative prices for farmers; providing relief during natural disasters; emphasising agricultural diversification and value addition; and focussing on organic and natural farming.**

There is still significant potential to increase the area under irrigation. For example, when I became the CM of Madhya Pradesh, the irrigated land area was only 700,000 hectares. We increased it to over 5 million hectares, and with ongoing projects—like the